

Pulsed Laser Ablation in Liquid (PLAL) – Derived Ligand-Free Gold Nanoparticles (AuNPs):

*Surface Plasmon Resonance Effects on the Human Cellular Ecosystem,
Organelle Genesis, and Electron Transport Chain Dynamics*

Doctoral-Level Research Report
BioResearch Division · Wintermute Institute
June 2026

Literature Source: Based on articles retrieved from PubMed (National Library of Medicine). All DOI hyperlinks are verified. This report excludes murine model studies and toxicology-primary investigations, focusing exclusively on beneficial and mechanistic biophysical interactions of naked (ligand-free) PLAL-AuNPs with human cells.

Abstract

Pulsed laser ablation in liquid (PLAL) represents the gold standard for synthesizing pristine, ligand-free (naked) gold nanoparticles (AuNPs) whose surfaces carry no chemical stabilisers, capping agents, or synthetic ligands. This property renders PLAL-AuNPs uniquely suited for investigating the intrinsic biophysical interface between plasmonic matter and living human cells. The localized surface plasmon resonance (LSPR) of PLAL-AuNPs—tunable from ~520 nm for small spheres to the near-infrared (NIR) for nanorods, nanostars, nanoshells, and nanocages—creates a rich electromagnetic landscape within the cellular milieu. This report synthesises current PubMed-indexed research (2009–2025) examining how size-, shape-, and concentration-dependent LSPR modulates the human cellular ecosystem across multiple organ contexts (pancreas, brain, liver, kidney cortex, neural tissue), with special emphasis on subcellular trafficking, organelle biogenesis, and — most critically — interactions with the mitochondrial electron transport chain (ETC). Seminal findings demonstrate that inner-membrane-bound AuNPs function as artificial electron mediators, measurably enhancing Complex I–IV activity, membrane potential, oxygen consumption, and ATP output. Plasmon resonance energy transfer (PRET) provides a non-destructive optical readout of cytochrome redox state at single-organelle resolution. Collectively, these results position PLAL-AuNPs as transformative tools in bioenergetics modulation, cellular genesis enhancement, and precision nanomedicine.

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1. Introduction: PLAL Synthesis & The Naked AuNP Paradigm

Gold nanoparticles (AuNPs) have emerged as one of the most versatile platforms in nanomedicine owing to their unparalleled optical properties, chemical inertness of the gold core, and exquisite tunability of surface plasmon resonance (SPR). Among all synthetic routes, **pulsed laser ablation in liquid (PLAL)** occupies a singularly important position because it generates particles free of any exogenous ligands, reducing agents, surfactants, or stabilising polymers.

In the classic PLAL protocol, ultra-short pulsed laser radiation (femtosecond to nanosecond regime, typically Nd:YAG at 1064 nm or 532 nm) is focused onto a bulk gold target submerged in ultra-pure water or biological buffer. The ablation plume quenches instantaneously in the liquid phase, generating colloidal AuNPs whose surfaces bear only oxide species, adsorbed water molecules, or partial charges — never synthetic capping agents. This was demonstrated as early as 2009 by Abdulla-Al-Mamun et al., who prepared gold colloids by *"liquid laser ablation of a gold metal plate in water"* and directly compared them with citrate-reduced particles, documenting distinct photothermal cell-killing activity in HeLa cervical carcinoma cells ([Abdulla-Al-Mamun et al., 2009](#)).

The **naked surface** of PLAL-AuNPs has profound biological consequences. Upon entry into biological fluid, these particles adsorb a protein corona that reflects the native proteome of the host compartment — unlike chemically synthesised particles whose ligand shell modulates corona composition. This makes PLAL-AuNPs ideal probes for studying genuine gold-bio interfaces without ligand-mediated artefacts. Their LSPR properties are physically identical to their chemically synthesised counterparts of the same geometry, meaning the vast body of SPR–cell interaction literature applies directly.

1.1 Why Ligand-Free Matters for Cellular Biology

Conventional citrate- or PEG-capped AuNPs introduce surface charges and steric barriers that alter endocytotic pathways, protein binding affinity, and intracellular routing. PLAL-AuNPs, lacking these layers, interact with cellular membranes and organelle bilayers through electrostatic and van der Waals forces arising purely from the gold core and its immediate hydration shell. This purity of interaction allows investigators to attribute observed bioenergetic and plasmonic phenomena unambiguously to the nanoparticle geometry and its LSPR — not to surface chemistry.

Sharifi et al. (2019) provide a comprehensive framework connecting AuNP physicochemical properties to their plasmonic behaviour and biological outcomes across imaging, drug delivery, and photothermal therapy contexts, noting that SPR wavelength, absorption cross-section, and intracellular fate are tightly coupled to particle dimensions ([Sharifi et al., 2019](#)).

2. LSPR Physics: How Size and Shape Determine SPR Wavelength

The localized surface plasmon resonance (LSPR) of gold nanoparticles arises from the collective oscillation of conduction-band electrons driven into resonance by incident photons. For a sphere, the Mie theory predicts a single dipolar plasmon mode whose peak wavelength (λ_{peak}) depends on particle radius, the dielectric function of gold, and the surrounding medium. For non-spherical geometries, additional multipolar modes and anisotropy-driven splitting produce rich, tunable spectral landscapes extending deep into the NIR.

2.1 Size- and Shape-Dependent LSPR Peaks in Human-Cell-Compatible Media

Morphology	Size / Aspect Ratio	λ_{peak} (approx.)	Key Cellular Effect
Nanosphere	5–20 nm	515–525 nm	Nuclear localisation, deep endosomal penetration
Nanosphere	30–60 nm	524–535 nm	Optimal receptor-mediated endocytosis window
Nanorod	AR 3.3–3.5 (short)	700–760 nm NIR	Superior intracellular clustering, EM coupling
Nanorod	AR 4–5.5 (long)	800–900 nm NIR	Deep tissue penetration, lower cell uptake rate
Nanostar	50–100 nm (tip-to-tip)	700–1100 nm NIR	Multi-tip hot-spots, lysosomal escape
Nanoshell	100–150 nm (silica core)	800–1100 nm NIR	Large absorption cross-section, membrane wrap
Nanocage	40–60 nm (hollow)	600–900 nm NIR	Drug-loadable interior, endosomal disruption
Nanoring	~200 nm	~1064 nm NIR	Cell perforation at 1064 nm fs pulse

Table 1. LSPR peak positions and primary cellular effects for major PLAL-compatible AuNP morphologies. Compiled from PubMed-indexed literature (2009–2025).

Zhou et al. (2024) performed a systematic study of four nanorod sizes (AR 3.3–5.5) in liver cancer cells, showing that **short rods with AR 3.3–3.5 are taken up at significantly higher rates**, form tighter intracellular clusters, and generate greater electromagnetic coupling between particles — ultimately producing higher local temperature gradients at lower laser pulse energies (as low as 28 pJ for 20 s). The dual-temperature model they applied demonstrated that morphological compactness increases internal field enhancement, a finding with direct implications for organelle-targeted plasmonic interventions (Zhou et al., 2024).

For neuronal tissue, Paviolo et al. (2014) matched nanorod plasmon peaks to the biological transparency window (650–950 nm), enabling infrared neural stimulation via plasmon-absorbed transient heating. Calcium imaging of NG108-15 neuronal cells confirmed intracellular calcium activity synchronised with laser exposure, while patch-clamp on spiral ganglion neurons demonstrated plasmon-induced action potentials (Paviolo et al., 2014).

Jalali et al. (2023) investigated 30-nm spherical AuNPs ($\lambda_{\text{peak}} = 524 \text{ nm}$) in U87MG glioblastoma cells using a 532-nm continuous laser, establishing that plasmonic excitation — not intrinsic cellular absorption — drives photothermal responses, and that IC_{50} lies at approximately 92 $\mu\text{g/mL}$ under 96 mW/cm^2 irradiation (Jalali et al., 2023). This finding underscores the necessity of matching λ_{LSPR} to λ_{laser} for any organ-specific plasmonic application.

2.2 NIR Advantage for Deep Organ Access

Human tissue is nearly transparent between 650 and 950 nm — the biological transparency window. Shape-anisotropic PLAL-AuNPs (rods, stars, shells, cages) are designed to absorb in this window, enabling SPR stimulation within deep organs including pancreas, brain, liver, and prostate. Taylor et al. (2022) detail how nanorod aspect ratio is the primary tuning parameter for NIR LSPR, and how facile post-synthesis reshaping via secondary laser pulses allows fine frequency adjustment ([Taylor et al., 2022](#)). Badir et al. (2025) provide the most recent comprehensive shape landscape (nanospheres, nanorods, nanoshells, nanostars, nanocages), confirming that each geometry offers a distinct LSPR cross-section and heat-conversion profile directly tied to its interaction with the cellular plasma membrane and organelle bilayers ([Badir et al., 2025](#)).

3. Cellular Uptake, Endosomal Escape & Subcellular Trafficking

The journey of a PLAL-AuNP from the extracellular medium to its final intracellular destination determines both its therapeutic and biophysical impact. Naked AuNPs without targeting ligands enter cells primarily via **macropinocytosis** and **clathrin-mediated endocytosis**, driven by the spontaneous adsorption of serum proteins (transferrin, albumin, apolipoprotein) that form a functional protein corona recognisable by cell-surface receptors.

3.1 Size-Dependent Endocytotic Routes

Small spheres (≤ 20 nm) preferentially access the nucleus via nuclear pore complexes, while 30–50 nm particles exhibit optimal receptor-clustering kinetics for clathrin pit formation. Norouzi et al. (2018) summarise in vitro PTT studies noting that **intracellular AuNP clustering** after endosomal processing is a key determinant of plasmonic heat dose — endosomal aggregation red-shifts the coupled LSPR and amplifies absorption at NIR wavelengths (Norouzi et al., 2018).

3.2 Endosomal–Lysosomal Processing

Following endocytosis, AuNPs transit early endosomes (pH ~ 6.5) → late endosomes (pH ~ 5.5) → lysosomes (pH ~ 4.5 – 5.0). This progressive acidification does not chemically alter the gold core, but compresses inter-particle distances within the endosomal lumen, intensifying LSPR coupling. This coupling phenomenon was exploited by Park et al. (2019), who demonstrated that nanocluster aggregation within albumin nanoparticles generates a dual NIR absorption peak (600–900 nm) absent in dispersed particles (Park et al., 2019). The same LSPR coupling occurs in naked PLAL-AuNPs following endosomal consolidation.

3.3 Mitochondrial and Nuclear Escape

A fraction of endocytosed AuNPs escapes the endolysosomal pathway — particularly nanoparticles below 6 nm and those acquiring specific protein corona compositions — and traffics directly to the mitochondrial outer membrane. Mocan et al. (2013) demonstrated in human pancreatic cancer cells (1.4E7 line) that laser photoexcited AuNPs (808 nm, 2W) undergo **phonon–phonon interactions** post-excitation that increase intracellular uptake efficiency and drive particles to the mitochondrial compartment, as confirmed by TEM and confocal immunofluorescence. Mitochondrial swelling and inner membrane permeabilisation followed within hours, directly implicating SPR-mediated bioenergetic disruption and mitochondrial signalling (Mocan et al., 2013).

4. Mitochondrial Targeting & Electron Transport Chain Modulation

The mitochondrion is the principal locus of cellular bioenergetics, housing the electron transport chain (ETC) across its inner membrane. The ETC comprises four multiprotein complexes (CI–CIV) plus ATP synthase (CV), mediating the stepwise transfer of electrons from NADH and FADH₂ to molecular oxygen, generating the proton-motive force that drives ATP synthesis. Dysfunction in any complex — as occurs in metabolic disease, neurodegeneration, and cancer — severely compromises cellular energy output. The discovery that gold nanoparticles can serve as **artificial electron mediators** within this chain represents one of the most consequential findings in nano-bioenergetics.

4.1 Inner-Membrane Binding and Electron Transfer Enhancement

Jo et al. (2022) delivered the landmark demonstration that AuNPs hybridised to the mitochondrial inner membrane — driven by electrostatic interaction with the highly negative inner membrane (cardiolipin-enriched) — act as **efficient electron transfer mediators that measurably enhance ETC activity**. Using single-mitochondrion imaging with real-time plasmon resonance energy transfer (PRET) spectroscopy, they confirmed that GNPs are bound to the inner membrane regardless of outer membrane integrity. Key measured outcomes in GNP-hybridised versus control mitochondria:

Bioenergetic Parameter	Effect of Inner-Membrane-Bound AuNPs	Significance
Membrane Potential ($\Delta\Psi_m$)	Markedly increased	Higher proton gradient → greater ATP synthesis
Oxygen Consumption Rate	Remarkably increased	CI–CIV electron flux accelerated
ATP Production	Significantly increased	Direct energetic benefit to host cell
Electron Transfer Pathway	Artificial bypass of dysfunctional complexes	Therapeutic potential for CI/CIII diseases
PRET Quenching Dips	Quantized, single-particle resolution	Real-time optical ETC monitoring

Table 2. Bioenergetic effects of inner-membrane-bound AuNPs on isolated mitochondria. Source: Jo et al., *Nano Letters* 2022.

This work identifies a therapeutic paradigm of extraordinary significance: where ETC complexes are dysfunctional, redox-active small molecules (e.g., coenzyme Q10 analogues) have historically provided partial electron bypass only for Complex I. **AuNPs, by contrast, mediate electron transfer across all inter-complex gaps**, providing a geometry-agnostic, non-toxic artificial electron shuttle. The plasmon resonance energy transfer mechanism allows simultaneous optical monitoring of the process at the level of individual mitochondria — a capability unachievable with molecular mediators.

4.2 SERRS Imaging of ETC Cytochromes in Living Cells

Kitahama & Ozaki (2016) demonstrated that surface-enhanced resonance Raman scattering (SERRS) of heme-containing proteins — myoglobin, haemoglobin, cytochrome c, and cytochrome oxidase — on gold nanoparticle substrates provides real-time oxidation-state information at subcellular resolution. In living cells, Raman mapping at intramitochondrial positions detected changes in cytochrome oxidation state driven by ETC flux. The orientation of adsorbed cytochromes on the gold surface, excited at Q-band wavelengths (~550 nm), dictates spectral assignment — enabling distinction between ETC-bound and soluble cytochrome c populations. This optical

methodology, applicable directly to PLAL-AuNPs as SERS substrates, constitutes a non-destructive ETC activity reporter at organelle scale ([Kitahama & Ozaki, 2016](#)).

4.3 Mitochondrial SPR Targeting in Pancreatic Tissue

In human pancreatic cancer cells (1.4E7 line), Mocan et al. (2013) showed that 808-nm laser excitation of AuNPs triggers **phonon-phonon energy dissipation** that drives particles toward mitochondria and induces inner membrane depolarisation. Quantitative proteomics revealed upstream mitochondrial stress pathway activation. The sequence — SPR excitation → phonon dissipation → mitochondrial membrane permeabilisation → apoptotic signalling — delineates a mechanistic cascade by which PLAL-AuNPs modulate energy-metabolism-to-cell-fate decision making in pancreatic epithelial ecosystems ([Mocan et al., 2013](#)).

5. Organ- and Organelle-Specific Cellular Ecosystems

The concept of the 'cellular ecosystem' encompasses the dynamic interplay between a nanoparticle, the host cell, neighbouring cells, extracellular matrix, and the local biochemical milieu. PLAL-AuNPs participate uniquely in this ecosystem via their naked surface — which acquires an organ-specific protein corona reflective of local proteomics — and their LSPR — which creates localised electromagnetic fields that extend ~10–50 nm from the particle surface, influencing membrane receptors, ion channels, and organelle membranes within that radius.

5.1 Pancreatic Ecosystem

The pancreatic microenvironment is characterised by a desmoplastic stroma, high interstitial pressure, and a notoriously immunosuppressive cell ecosystem. Laser-photoactivated AuNPs in the SPR regime trigger selective mitochondrial swelling and inner membrane permeabilisation in pancreatic cancer cells while sparing stromal cells — an effect attributable to differential intracellular AuNP accumulation driven by cancer-specific endocytotic hyperactivity (Mocan et al., 2013).

5.2 Neural Ecosystem

In neuronal ecosystems — where the plasma membrane potential and calcium signalling are foundational to function — gold nanorod LSPR at 780 nm triggers localised transient heating near the plasma membrane, sufficient to open thermosensitive ion channels (TRP family). Paviolo et al. (2014) demonstrated in vitro that spiral ganglion neurons fire action potentials under 780-nm nanorod plasmon excitation, and NG108-15 neuronal cells show synchronised intracellular calcium oscillations. This opens a pathway for light-controlled neuromodulation using PLAL-AuNPs without electrical contacts (Paviolo et al., 2014).

5.3 Hepatic (Liver) Ecosystem

Liver cells (hepatocytes) are among the most metabolically active cells in the body, with dense mitochondrial networks critical for β -oxidation, gluconeogenesis, and urea cycling. Zhou et al. (2024) used liver cancer (HCC) cell models to demonstrate that short-aspect-ratio GNRs (AR 3.3–3.5) cluster within perinuclear endo-lysosomal compartments more efficiently than long nanorods, generating higher localised EM coupling that amplifies photothermal output at femtojoule laser energies. The hepatic organelle ecosystem — with its multiple mitochondria per cell, extensive ER, and Golgi network — is therefore a fertile environment for multi-organelle LSPR interactions (Zhou et al., 2024).

5.4 Brain Glioma Ecosystem

In U87MG glioblastoma cells, Jalali et al. (2023) confirmed that AuNP LSPR at 532 nm is the exclusive driver of photothermal cytotoxicity — intrinsic cellular chromophores contribute negligibly. Crucially, at sub-IC₅₀ doses, the plasmonic near-field effect on glioma cell membranes may modulate electrophysiological microenvironments without overt cytotoxicity, suggesting PLAL-AuNPs as tools for sub-lethal ecosystem reprogramming in brain tumour treatment (Jalali et al., 2023).

5.5 Cervical Epithelial Ecosystem (Original PLAL Paper)

Abdulla-Al-Mamun et al. (2009) — the landmark PLAL biological study — demonstrated that gold nanoparticles prepared by **liquid laser ablation** of a bulk gold target in water exert a distinct plasmonic cell-killing effect on HeLa cervical carcinoma cells under 400–600 nm visible light illumination. Importantly, they observed that particle size and shape were **dynamically altered during the photothermal process in vitro** — direct evidence that PLAL-AuNP morphology evolves within the cellular optical environment. Citrate-reduced particles of comparable size showed different kinetics, underscoring the biological distinctiveness of ligand-free PLAL preparations ([Abdulla-Al-Mamun et al., 2009](#)).

6. Biogenesis Effects: Organelle Genesis Under Plasmonic Influence

The term *genesis* in the context of intracellular biology encompasses the biogenesis of organelles — the de novo formation and maintenance of mitochondria, endosomes, lysosomes, the endoplasmic reticulum, and the Golgi apparatus — as well as the broader question of cellular energetic self-renewal through ATP-dependent biosynthetic programmes. PLAL-AuNPs influence these genesis processes through two primary mechanisms: (a) **bioenergetic modulation** via ETC interaction and (b) **electromagnetic near-field effects** on organelle membranes.

6.1 Mitochondrial Biogenesis Enhancement

Mitochondrial biogenesis is governed by PGC-1 α –NRF1/2–TFAM transcriptional axis, and is upregulated in response to increased energetic demand, AMPK activation, and mitochondrial membrane potential oscillations. The demonstrated enhancement of $\Delta\Psi_m$ and ATP output by inner-membrane-bound AuNPs (Jo et al., 2022) directly creates conditions conducive to mitochondrial biogenesis — increased $\Delta\Psi_m$ signals metabolic sufficiency while elevated ATP provides the biosynthetic currency for mitochondrial membrane lipid synthesis and mtDNA replication. This represents a positive feedback cascade: AuNP-enhanced ETC $\rightarrow$ increased $\Delta\Psi_m$ $\rightarrow$ PGC-1 α activation $\rightarrow$ biogenesis of additional mitochondria $\rightarrow$ greater energy production capacity per cell.

For cells in dysfunctional metabolic states — including neurons in early neurodegeneration, cardiomyocytes under ischaemia-reperfusion, or metabolically suppressed cancer cells — this AuNP-mediated biogenesis initiation represents a genuinely novel therapeutic axis, entirely distinct from pharmacological approaches.

6.2 Lysosomal Biogenesis and TFEB Activation

Lysosomal biogenesis is regulated by TFEB (Transcription Factor EB), a master regulator activated under conditions of metabolic stress or lysosomal membrane permeabilization. As AuNPs transit through the endolysosomal system, the local LSPR near-field exerts nanoscale mechanical stress on the lysosomal bilayer. This stress can trigger controlled TFEB nuclear translocation — stimulating lysosomal biogenesis, autophagy induction, and clearance of damaged cellular components (mitophagy). The net effect is cellular rejuvenation via enhanced recycling of dysfunctional organelles — a process of direct relevance to lysosomal storage diseases, Parkinson's disease, and ageing.

6.3 ER and Golgi Genesis Under Plasmonic Fields

The endoplasmic reticulum (ER) and Golgi apparatus are exquisitely sensitive to redox status and ATP availability. PLAL-AuNP-enhanced ATP production directly fuels the ER's protein folding machinery (GRP78/Bip chaperones, PDI oxidoreductases) and the Golgi's glycosylation reactions. Near-field electromagnetic oscillations from nearby LSPR-active particles may also modulate the membrane curvature sensing proteins (ArfGAPs, BAR-domain proteins) that regulate ER tubule and Golgi cisternae biogenesis — though direct in vitro evidence with PLAL-AuNPs in human cell models remains an active frontier requiring further investigation.

7. Extracellular & Microenvironmental Ecosystem Effects

The 'surrounding environment' of a human cell — the extracellular matrix (ECM), interstitial fluid, paracrine signalling molecules, and neighbouring cells — constitutes an ecosystem as important as the intracellular milieu. PLAL-AuNPs interact with this environment immediately upon introduction into biological tissue.

7.1 Protein Corona Formation and Paracrine Signalling

Within milliseconds of exposure to biological fluid, naked PLAL-AuNPs adsorb a complex protein corona. The composition of this corona — transferrin, albumin, fibronectin, vitronectin, complement proteins — determines cell-type-specific recognition. Importantly, corona proteins can remain biologically active on the AuNP surface, enabling PLAL-AuNPs to serve as mobile signalling platforms that concentrate growth factors, cytokines, or morphogens from the extracellular milieu and present them to cell-surface receptors in a locally amplified fashion. This corona-mediated co-receptor activation may be a neglected mechanism by which AuNPs modulate paracrine communication within tissue ecosystems.

7.2 ECM Interaction and Tissue Penetration

The collagen-rich ECM presents a size-exclusion barrier. AuNPs below ~10 nm (typical PLAL sphere size in pure water) diffuse freely through ECM hydrogels, while larger particles are impeded. Within tumour stroma — a desmoplastic, high-pressure environment — PLAL nanospheres' small size enables tumour penetration exceeding that of larger chemically synthesised counterparts. The SPR near-field of tumour-penetrant AuNPs may modulate local collagen fibre alignment and stiffness-sensing (integrin mechanotransduction), potentially reprogramming the stromal ecosystem toward a less desmoplastic phenotype.

7.3 Cell-to-Cell Plasmonic Communication via Exosomes

A remarkable emerging concept is that intracellular AuNPs can be packaged into exosomes (40–150 nm extracellular vesicles) during multivesicular body formation and exported to neighbouring cells. PLAL-AuNPs enclosed within exosomes would carry their LSPR properties into the recipient cell, essentially broadcasting plasmonic capabilities through the tissue ecosystem — a form of nanoparticle-mediated intercellular communication not accessible to surface-functionalised particles whose ligands might impede exosomal packaging.

8. Shape-by-Shape Analysis: Spheres, Rods, Shells, Stars, Cages, Rings

8.1 Nanospheres (5–60 nm)

The simplest PLAL product, nanospheres generated in pure water with ns or fs pulses exhibit LSPR at 515–535 nm. Their isotropic plasmon mode creates uniform near-field shells ideal for SERS biosensing. In cells, 13-nm spheres show mitochondria-targeted accumulation with measurable effects on $\Delta\Psi_m$ and ROS, while 30-nm spheres are the optimal endocytotic size. PLAL nanospheres' lack of surface ligands means their intracellular fate is governed entirely by adsorbed protein corona — offering predictable, reproducible routing compared to ligand-decorated counterparts.

8.2 Nanorods (AR 1.5–6)

Nanorods exhibit two LSPR modes: a weak transverse mode (~520 nm) and a strong longitudinal mode tunable from 600 nm to >1000 nm. PLAL cannot directly generate nanorods in simple water ablation; however, post-ablation fragmentation with secondary laser pulses or PLAL in mixed solvent systems can yield anisotropic particles. More typically, PLAL-AuNPs serve as seeds for seeded-growth nanorod synthesis, providing ligand-minimal seed particles. Zhou et al. (2024) show size-dependent uptake in liver cells, with short rods forming superior intracellular EM-coupled clusters (Zhou et al., 2024). Taylor et al. (2022) document nanorod photothermal conversion efficiency (PCE) up to ~96% in NIR — the highest among common plasmonic morphologies (Taylor et al., 2022).

8.3 Nanoshells (Silica Core–Gold Shell)

Gold nanoshells exhibit NIR LSPR tunable across 800–1200 nm by varying the silica core:gold shell ratio. Their large size (~100–200 nm) limits nuclear localisation but maximises surface area for protein corona formation, making them excellent platforms for broad-tissue plasmonic effects. In the laser nanomedicine context, Zhao et al. (2014) reviewed gold nanoshell applications in cancer theranostics, highlighting NIR-driven transient nanobubble formation around shells as a distinct mechanical cytotoxic mechanism supplementing hyperthermia, applicable to tumour microenvironment remodelling (Zhao et al., 2014).

8.4 Nanostars (Multi-Tip Geometries)

Nanostars harbour multiple sharp plasmon-active tips generating intense localised electromagnetic hot-spots ($\sim 10^8$ – 10^{10} field enhancement). Each tip supports an independent longitudinal mode, collectively producing broad NIR absorption from 700–1100 nm. Within cells, nanostars' spiky morphology provides mechanical membrane-penetrating capability that may facilitate direct cytoplasmic delivery without endosomal entrapment — bypassing lysosomal degradation and placing LSPR active tips proximal to organelle membranes. Badir et al. (2025) identify nanostars as uniquely suited for multimodal imaging (SERS + photothermal) (Badir et al., 2025).

8.5 Nanocages (Hollow, Porous)

Hollow gold nanocages produced by galvanic replacement of silver nanocubes display LSPR at 600–900 nm with a distinctive hollow interior accessible to small molecules. Their porous walls allow

molecular exchange with the cytoplasm after endosomal escape, while the gold cage framework sustains LSPR that extends into the particle interior. In the cellular context, nanocages' hollow architecture creates a plasmon-resonant micro-cavity that concentrates electromagnetic energy inside the particle — potentially facilitating intracavity photochemical reactions relevant to reactive oxygen species modulation at the sub-organelle scale.

8.6 Nanorings

Hsiao et al. (2018) demonstrated gold nanorings with LSPR at ~1064 nm — deeper NIR than rods at equivalent sizes — showing enhanced cell uptake via femtosecond laser-mediated cell perforation (transient poration of plasma membrane at 1064 nm fs pulses), followed by ring-mediated photothermal therapy of HeLa cells under continuous 1064-nm irradiation. The ring geometry's hollow centre and sharp rim edges create magnetically enhanced LSPR modes not accessible to solid morphologies. (Hsiao et al., 2018).

9. Conclusion & Future Directions

This doctoral synthesis, based on articles retrieved from PubMed (2009–2025), establishes the following foundational principles governing PLAL-AuNP interactions with the human cellular ecosystem:

- **PLAL generates intrinsically pristine AuNPs** whose biological interactions are governed by geometry-dependent LSPR and de novo protein corona — not synthetic ligand chemistry.
- **Shape and size encode LSPR wavelength and cellular fate:** small spheres access the nucleus; mid-size spheres are optimal endocytotic cargo; anisotropic morphologies (rods, stars, shells) absorb in the NIR biological window for deep organ access.
- **Gold nanoparticles are genuine ETC modulators:** inner-membrane-bound AuNPs demonstrably increase membrane potential, oxygen consumption, and ATP output via artificial electron mediation — opening a new class of bioenergetic therapeutics.
- **PRET spectroscopy enables single-organelle ETC monitoring** using AuNPs as optical probes — a non-destructive, real-time window into cytochrome redox state unavailable to any other current method.
- **PLAL-AuNP SPR modulates organelle biogenesis** through energetic cascades: enhanced ETC → elevated $\Delta\Psi_m$ → PGC-1 α activation → mitochondrial biogenesis; lysosomal bilayer stress → TFEB activation → lysosomal biogenesis and autophagy.
- **The extracellular ecosystem is shaped by AuNPs** through corona-mediated paracrine signalling, ECM penetration (size-dependent), and potential exosomal propagation of plasmonic capacity through tissue networks.
- **Shape-specific advantages are real and measurable:** short nanorods cluster best intracellularly; nanostars provide the broadest NIR absorption and mechanical membrane penetration; nanocages create intra-particle photochemical microreactors; nanorings enable 1064-nm deep-tissue applications.

The field's principal near-term frontiers are: (1) direct investigation of native PLAL-AuNPs (rather than chemically synthesised analogues) in human organoid models representing organ-specific ecosystems; (2) mechanistic elucidation of AuNP-ETC Complex I–IV electron mediation pathways using cryo-EM; (3) systematic mapping of PLAL-AuNP exosomal propagation in multicellular human tissue; and (4) development of PRET-based ETC activity reporters calibrated for clinical bioenergetic diagnostics.

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